green jacket, they threw him into a cattle-pen, from which he was rescued only after the village was besieged by Maulana Pir Mohammad Shirwani and the imperial troops. On another occasion, Akbar found himself hungry and thirsty, as well as alone, at the end of a long hunt and walked into the shack of a bhatiyari (female innkeeper) and ate a meal. The meal would have been simple, perhaps consisting of ‘rice boiled with green ginger, a little pepper and butter; bread made of a coarse grain…baked on a small round iron hearth; boiled lentils; and local fruit and vegetables’. Some fellow-travellers, unimpressed with the bedraggled aspect of the hunter, ‘gave him a few lashes and told him to get out of the place’.

The young Padshah, it was noted, became exceedingly fond of cockfights at this time. Cockerels, bred to fight to the death, would duel each other in an enclosed pit. Every nobleman who came to perform the kornish, the salutation to the emperor, was urged to remember to bring a cock along. There was much amusement when Ataka Khan played a prank on the emperor by bringing a hen to fight with the royal cock.

The prosaic workings of empire also continued while the young Padshah found novel filters through which to understand his land and his people. The jagirs of noblemen were now increasingly seen as a fixed income, for which they were assigned a collection of villages, called a pargana.* These crucial assignments were the responsibility of the central diwan. This revenue assignment was meant to be quite separate from the territories that the noblemen were required to administer. During these early years of Akbar’s empire, the parganas that were assigned to a nobleman were largely contiguous, leading to a worrying concentration of land controlled by these powerful noblemen, with an even more troubling tendency for the jagirs assigned to particular clans of men to all be grouped together in areas of potential strife. This meant that there was also a very slow rotation of the assignment of these jagirs. Within a few years, in 1565, clan distribution would be dangerously concentrated as follows, as described by Iqtidar Alam Khan:

> Uzbeks in the Jaunpur region; Qaqshals in Kara-Manikpur; Jalairs in Lucknow and Awadh; Mirzas in Sambhal; and the Atka clan in the Punjab.

While these clans were anchoring themselves within their territories and Akbar was immersing himself in unconventional discoveries, others were